All Hail Hurricane Gordo

By Carly Mensch

(A living room turned makeshift office. Two desks, one neat and organized with a typewriter and carefully arranged stacks of paper and the other a total wreck, purgatory-like, where things half-eaten and half-assed take up residence. There is a worn-out couch dead center covered with piles and piles of phone books and a lone wooden chair in the corner.) (CHAZ, late 20s, sits at the neat desk. Shirt and tie. Typing. Enter GORDO, mid 20s. In boxers and a little boys' pajama top. CHAZ continues typing. GORDO watches for a moment.)

GORDO: Hey. *(Type type. Type type.)* Hey Chaz. *(CHAZ doesn't respond. GORDO patiently repeats himself)* Chaz. Chaz. Chaz.

CHAZ: I hear you.

GORDO: You want breakfast?

CHAZ: Already ate. *(GORDO exits. CHAZ pulls out the sheet of paper from the typewriter and puts it into an envelope. He finds the appropriate address in one of the phone books open on his desk.) (GORDO returns with some old mush in Tupperware. He loiters around CHAZ's desk while he eats.)* What is that?

GORDO: Stir-fry.

CHAZ: From last week? You didn't see any cereal? *(GORDO shrugs.)* I bought some yesterday.

GORDO: You bought the bad kind.

CHAZ: I bought Cheerios.

GORDO: You bought Shit-e-os. The kind in the plastic bag. The kind you have to crawl on the floor of the supermarket to get. They look like Cheerios but surprise - they're really Shit-e-os. Simple mistake.

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INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *Two brothers . . . both in their 20s . . . living on their own.*
ACTOR 2: *Abandoned years ago in a parking lot by their mother, who found herself overwhelmed by life.*
ACTOR 1: *In order to make sure that Children's Services does not separate them, the older brother Chaz, hides Gordo, his emotionally challenged brother.*
ACTOR 2: *They return to their family home and work enough to pay for basic necessities.*
ACTOR 1: *Chaz sells off the family possessions and struggles to be the parent, all the while searching for other family members who can help --*
ACTOR 2: *Chaz' infamous "letter" campaign. --*
ACTOR 1: *Just what are our responsibilities to our loved ones?*
ACTOR 2: *And how do we find a balance when those responsibilities are in conflict with our responsibilities to ourselves.*
TOGETHER: *All Hail Hurricane Gordo*

GORDO: How long you been working?

CHAZ: Little over an hour.

GORDO: Jeez. That's discipline.

CHAZ: Just finished the fourth one this morning. Oh. And we need to pick up more stamps. We're running low.

GORDO: Look at you. You're like this self-guided missile. Like your brain is on autopilot.

CHAZ: It's after ten by the way. We start at nine thirty.

GORDO: Yeah ... I can't get up then. Sorry.

CHAZ: Why not?

GORDO: Because. You got rid of the IV. That's how I used to tell time - the channel guide. I used to watch the channel guide every morning until breakfast. Do you know you can basically schedule your entire life just by watching the channel guide? It tells you what's on and when and how long, and there's even a little ticking clock in the upper hand corner. But now it's just. . . nothing. Where's my compass? Where's my best friend?

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Oh yeah, Chaz sold it on eBay.

CHAZ: I didn't sell it on eBay. I sold it to Kip Bearman.

GORDO: The guy from the Y? Now what's he gonna do with a TV? Smoke it?

CHAZ: *(amused)* Please tell me how you smoke a television set.

GORDO: Oh he'll figure out a way. He'll probably pull out all the wires and try to snort the electricity out of them.

CHAZ: What makes you think he does drugs? We see him at the pool, that's it.

GORDO: And on the bench outside, waiting for the bus. Smoking Lucky Strikes. Every Wednesday, just sitting on the bench. Smoking.

CHAZ: Cigarettes.

GORDO: Cigarettes are a drug, man. They've got nicotine. You smoke one and Bang! your brain is a plate of scrambled eggs. Haven't you seen the commercials? Don't ever smoke, Chaz. Promise me you'll never smoke.

CHAZ: It's a little late for me to take up smoking, don't you think?

GORDO: *Promise* me, Chaz.

CHAZ: Fine. I promise.

GORDO: You can't die on me.

CHAZ: I'm not dying.

GORDO: I'm just saying, you better not. *(a moment)* I'm thinking of writing a letter. To Child Protective Services. With a note that says, "Dear Protective Services. Question: Do you really protect every child in America? Answer: No. You don't. Love, Gordon. P.S. Can you please get me a new TV?" *(CHAZ just stares at him.)*

CHAZ: Why don't you go get dressed.

GORDO: You don't think that's funny? Writing a letter to Child Protective Services?

CHAZ: It's not that funny anymore.

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GORDO: You write letters. You write like ten a day.

CHAZ: I write inquiries. It's a different thing.

GORDO: *(noticing)* What's up with the tie?

CHAZ: I've got a meeting today. We both do, actually.

GORDO: Ah we're auctioning off the couch. First the TV, now the couch. Everything must go!

CHAZ: We're not selling anything. It's - an interview.

GORDO: What kind of interview?

CHAZ: You can't get upset. Someone's coming here to interview with us.

GORDO: Why would they do that?

CHAZ: Go get dressed and we'll talk all about it.

GORDO: No. Tell me now, Chaz.

CHAZ: Not if you're going to freak out. It's no big deal. It's just a meeting.

GORDO: I'M NOT GOING TO FREAK OUT. Just tell me already. *(CHAZ composes himself)*

CHAZ: A potential tenant. She's coming in at eleven.

GORDO: *(GORDO processes all this.)* Okay. *(Beat. GORDO exits to his room. CHAZ watches the door warily. A few seconds later, GORDO re-enters wearing a football helmet. CHAZ stares at him for a moment.)*

CHAZ: Gordon. *(GORDO stares back.)* Gordo. *(GORDO lowers his head like a bull.)* Don't do this. *(GORDO kicks invisible dirt as if preparing to charge.)* I said don't. *(GORDO charges. Rams CHAZ in the stomach. CHAZ falls down.)* OFF! Off. Get OFF!

GORDO: AAGGHHH!!!!

CHAZ: Jesus. *(CHAZ tries to wiggle out from beneath GORDO)* I said off.

GORDO: I'M GOING TO BREAK YOUR ARM.

CHAZ: I need my arm.

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GORDO: NO YOU DON'T. NO. NO MORE ARM.

CHAZ: You know what time it is? I think you know what time it is.

GORDO: TIME TO EAT MY FACE! *(CHAZ manages to break free. Stands up.)*

CHAZ: I think it's time for a time out. Go sit in the chair.

GORDO: I don't want to sit in the chair.

CHAZ: You just head butt me in the stomach. I've probably got internal bleeding. Go have time out.

GORDO: Fine. *(GORDO goes to the lone wooden chair and takes a seat.)* How long?

CHAZ: Two minutes.

GORDO: One.

CHAZ: Fine. *(GORDO sits in the chair. Counts quietly to himself.)* I think you actually ruptured my spleen this time. *(CHAZ looks at his watch.)* 58 . . . 59 . . . 60. *(GORDO stands up.)* Are you ready to talk about this like a grown-up?

GORDO: Uh huh. I'm calm now. See? *(GORDO takes off the helmet.)* I don't know why I get so angry.

CHAZ: I think you've got some kind of anger management problem, maybe.

GORDO: Like elephants?

CHAZ: Yeah. Like elephants.

GORDO: Goring people in Asia, trampling entire villages in Africa. It's a worldwide epidemic you know. The whole animal kingdom's striking out. *(beat)* I don't want to be so angry all the time. It just comes out.

CHAZ: Well you've got to work on that. People aren't going to just accept that kind of behavior out in the real world. That's what got you into trouble, remember? You can't just do whatever you feel like. You're a human being. There are certain boundaries.

GORDO: You told me to always be myself.

CHAZ: Well. Not when your self is fiery ball of rage - okay? That's when you

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make an exception. *(beat)*

GORDO: You want me to fade into the darkness like some kind of phantasm.

CHAZ: I want you to be just a little more understanding, that's what I want.

GORDO: I'm very understanding. Trust me, I understand stuff.

CHAZ: I mean more understanding of me. Of what I need. I have needs too you know. I'm not just your babysitter. *(GORDO chuckles.)* I'm glad you find that so entertaining. Besides - It's not just that. It's also - money stuff.

GORDO: What happened?

CHAZ: Nothing happened. We could use the extra income, that's all.

GORDO: What about all the money I made at the airport?

CHAZ: You worked there for maybe three weeks.

GORDO: And not just that. I've had a lot of jobs, man. The library -

CHAZ: Two libraries - you've worked at two of them.

GORDO: What about when I gave people tours of the neighborhood and pretended that Amelia Earhart grew up here? I taught them all how to make paper airplanes so they'd have souvenirs to take back with them.

CHAZ: That doesn't count because you didn't charge them anything. In fact, you actually spent money because of all the paper.

GORDO: That was pretty funny though, right?

CHAZ: It was a little funny.

GORDO: What about you?

CHAZ: Oh - cause two jobs isn't bad enough.

GORDO: Do three.

CHAZ: Don't you think I'm pulling enough weight here already?

GORDO: You wake up at the crack of dawn. You're up anyway.

CHAZ: I get up early to do my personal business.

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GORDO: So I'll do that stuff. What - it's just writing letters and stuffing them into envelopes, right? I can do that.

CHAZ: You can't. It's my personal - it's something I do for myself, okay? It's mine. Besides - we wouldn't be in this situation if someone hadn't gotten himself fired from maybe the easiest job on the entire planet and probably blacklisted from the entire global job market.

GORDO: Hey- Can we talk about this person now?

CHAZ: Sure.

GORDO: So this person. It's a girl? Are you going to marry her?

CHAZ: I've never even met her.

GORDO: You said she was nice.

CHAZ: I talked to her on the phone.

GORDO: You can't marry her.

CHAZ: Who said I was? She'd be our *tenant.* And who are you to tell me who I can and cannot marry?

GORDO: Can't. Can't do it.

CHAZ: Yeah, you've said that. But why not?

GORDO: Because. *(beat)* I'm disabled. I have a social disorder.

CHAZ: You do not. It's all in your head.

GORDO: I have Asperger's. I looked it up.

CHAZ: How many fingers am I holding up right now? *(He holds up two fingers.)*

GORDO: Four?

CHAZ: You do not have Asperger's.

GORDO: You can't just go off with some girl and leave me alone.

CHAZ: How can I go anywhere? I've got to watch you like a hawk.

GORDO: You don't have to watch me.

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CHAZ: Are you kidding? What if you pull another stunt like you just did? What if you grab onto some stranger's ankles at the supermarket? What if you run away and hide out in a tool shed for the next five years eating nothing but paint chips and throwing pebbles at baby animals? Watch you? You might as well be made of cement and glued to the bottom of all my shoes the way things are. *(Pause. Feels bad.)* Now how bout you go change.

GORDO: I should shower first. If I'm going to put on clean clothes.

CHAZ: Great idea. Why don't you go take a shower.

GORDO: Okay. *(GORDO starts to exit.)* Hey, Chaz. You're a good brother. You take good care of me. *(pause)*

CHAZ: Gordo? Do you ever . . . Do you ever think about that whole day at the parking lot?

GORDO: *Whoa.* Where did that come from?

CHAZ: What do you remember? *(a slight pause)*

GORDO: Uh. I remember coupons. Lots and lots of coupons, all over the ground where we were sitting. I remember that.

CHAZ: Do you remember what Mom did?

GORDO: Mom?

CHAZ: Before she got in the car.

GORDO: She . . . I don't know. Tripped over a fire hydrant?

CHAZ: She put your hand in mine. She didn't say anything. She just gave me your hand.

GORDO: Yeah. I remember that. *(pause)*

CHAZ: You used to be pretty good at stuff, remember? You were good at English - you even got that story published in the school literary magazine - the one about me and you in the underwater castle. I don't

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know what happened. It's like I didn't give you the right vitamins.

GORDO: You didn't give me any vitamins.

CHAZ: You might have turned out different, that's all I'm saying.

GORDO: What are you talking about?

CHAZ: Mom and Dad. You would have been different.

GORDO: Yeah - so? I would have become some boring grown-up. I would drink coffee and talk about my taxes all the time. I'm my own person. I'm a force of nature.

CHAZ: But maybe – The way you act. I mean - what if I wasn't here? To clean up after you all the time.

GORDO: Why wouldn't you be here?

CHAZ: I might meet someone someday. I might, I don't know, get a job offer.

GORDO: No you wouldn't - don't even joke about that man.

CHAZ: Come on. You must have at least considered that I might not . . . always be here.

GORDO: Why would I consider that?

CHAZ: I'm just trying to broach the topic. To have a civil conversation with you.

GORDO: Well maybe you should try being a little less *aggressive* about it. Your basically mauling my soul with your so-called civil behavior. *(GORDO puts his fingers in his ears.) (frantic) (a long pause)* How about I take out the mail? Okay?

CHAZ: It's Sunday.

GORDO: So? Let me do my job. I'm good at that, right? *(GORDO picks up the mail container.)* Let's see what we've got this week *(He looks at the letters inside.)* Englewood, Colorado. You think we've got relatives all the way out there?

CHAZ: I don't know. Worth a shot. *(pause)*

GORDO: It's weird that no one ever responds.

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CHAZ: Got to keep trying -

GORDO: Sure, sure. It's just interesting, that's all.

(CHAZ returns to his desk. Opens up a phone book. Begins typing a letter.) (GORDO heads outside with the mail bin. We see him debate between the trash can and the mail box, then empty the mail bin into the trash can. He turns and smiles at the audience and gives them a thumbs up – giggles. Lights out)

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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